

B & D REALTY

The Buyer's Guide to Mexico

Riviera Maya · Cancun · Playa del Carmen · Tulum

Everything you need to know before you buy.

From legal structure to closing — straight talk, no fluff.

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01 — INTRODUCTION

Why Mexico?

The Riviera Maya is one of the last places in the world where you can still buy world-class real estate at a fraction of what comparable property costs in Miami, Ibiza, or the south of France. That window is closing. Fast.

Tourism here is structural, not seasonal. The region draws over 10 million international visitors per year, anchored by Cancun International Airport — one of the busiest in Latin America. Playa del Carmen, Tulum, and the hotel zones benefit from a captive, high-spending audience year-round.

Capital appreciation has been consistent. Tulum alone has seen values triple in parts of the market over the past decade. Infrastructure investment by the Mexican government — including the Tren Maya and new road networks — is accelerating that further.

"We are not selling you Mexico. We are helping you find your place in it — on the right terms."

02 — THE LEGAL STRUCTURE

Can foreigners buy property in Mexico?

Yes — with the right structure. Mexico's constitution restricts direct foreign ownership of property within 50km of the coast or 100km of a border. This is not a barrier. It simply means you hold title through one of two legal mechanisms:

Fideicomiso (Bank Trust)

A fideicomiso is a trust held by a Mexican bank on your behalf. You are the beneficiary with full rights to use, rent, sell, or transfer the property. It is renewable every 50 years and is the most common structure for foreign buyers. Annual fees typically run \$500–\$700 USD per year.

Mexican Corporation (S.A. de C.V.)

For investors purchasing for commercial use or multiple properties, a Mexican corporation can hold title directly. This structure has tax and operational advantages for rental income properties.

Step by Step

The process is straightforward when you know what to expect. Here is how it works:

01. Identify the Property

You find the right property — ideally with us. We vet it, check the title, confirm no liens, and verify the developer's track record if it's off-plan.

02. Offer & Negotiation

We present and negotiate your offer. In Mexico, there is significant room to negotiate — especially in a direct or off-market situation. This is where our relationships matter.

03. Promissory Agreement (Promesa)

A preliminary purchase agreement is signed with a deposit — typically 10–30%. This locks in price and terms while due diligence is completed.

04. Due Diligence

Title search, notario review, trust verification, and any outstanding fees or liens are cleared. This takes 2–4 weeks.

05. Closing with the Notario

The notario (a government-appointed public official, not a notary in the North American sense) executes the deed. All taxes and fees are paid at closing.

06. You Own It

Title transfers. Your fideicomiso is established. You have full rights to the property.

The entire process from signed offer to closing typically takes 4–8 weeks for resale properties, and follows the developer's timeline for pre-construction.

04 — COSTS TO EXPECT

What You Pay at Closing

Mexico's closing costs are higher than what North American buyers are used to. Budget 7–10% of the purchase price on top of the agreed sale price. Here is the breakdown:

Acquisition Tax (ISAI)

2–4% of purchase price. Varies by state. Quintana Roo is typically around 3%.

Notario Fees

1–1.5% of the purchase price. The notario handles all legal execution.

Fideicomiso Setup

\$1,000–\$1,500 USD one-time fee to establish the trust, plus annual fee of ~\$500–\$700.

Title Search & Legal

\$500–\$1,500 USD depending on complexity.

Agent Commission

In Mexico, the seller typically pays agent commission. As a buyer, you do not pay a separate commission. We represent your interests at no direct cost to you.

RFC (Tax ID)

You will need a Mexican tax ID number. We help you obtain one. Low cost, essential.

05 — THE LOCATIONS

Where to Buy

Cancun

Established infrastructure, strong rental yields, international airport access. Best for investors seeking liquidity and consistent rental income. The hotel zone commands premium prices; the north coast offers value.

Playa del Carmen

The sweet spot. Strong expat community, walkable lifestyle, established market. Mayakoba and Playacar represent the ultra-prime tier. Quinta Avenida drives tourism demand for short-term rentals.

Tulum

The fastest-appreciating market in the region. Bohemian luxury, jungle aesthetics, and a global audience. La Reserva, Aldea Zama, and the beach road are the key zones. Higher upside, higher complexity — know what you are buying.

What Buyers Get Wrong

Skipping the title search

Never skip it. Ejido land, unresolved liens, and missing permits are real risks that a proper search catches.

Trusting developer projections

Rental yield projections from developers are marketing, not guarantees. We give you real market data.

Choosing the wrong legal structure

Using a fideicomiso when you need a corporation (or vice versa) creates problems down the line. Get the right advice upfront.

Moving too slowly

Good properties — especially off-market — move fast. Indecision in this market is expensive.

Working without local representation

Mexico's real estate market is unregulated. Agents do not need a license. Most buyers who get burned do so because they had no one truly in their corner.

READY TO MOVE FORWARD?

This guide gives you the foundation. What it can't give you is the specific deal, the right negotiation position, or the off-market opportunity. That's where we come in.

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